



Multiple Personality Order

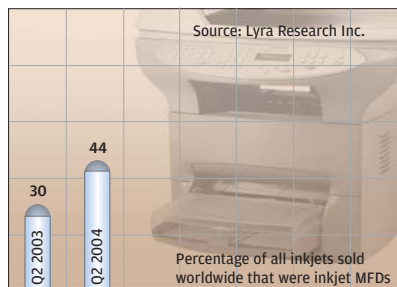
Multifunctional Devices or MFDs are fast becoming standard business tools. Do you already own one?

Preethi Chamikutty

As businesses move up the technology evolution scale, it is only natural that convergence makes its presence felt at the workplace. And more than one businessman would tell you that Multi-functional Devices (MFDs) are leading the way, at least in terms of hardware convergence.

Conventional research indicates that around 73 per cent of office work revolves around four tasks—printing, scanning, faxing and copying of documents. With such dependence on four tasks, it is logical that these devices enjoy such enormous popularity. The Indian peripherals market is now seeing an emergence of these products which is even eating into the traditional single function devices market. Experts peg the growth rate of the MFD market in 2005 at around 60-70 per cent.

The MFD market grew by a massive 160 per cent over the past 12 months, according to research group Inform, and colour inkjet models account for 85 per cent of the total MFD market. Little wonder, then, that printer manufacturers are flooding the market with new models.



What MFDs Offer Today

Space is a luxury not every office can afford. Hence consolidating three functions into a single device makes sense. The evolution of MFDs can be attributed to the demands of the customer in general.

Today almost all the companies in the running are trying to outdo each other. Inkjets still enjoy a larger market share compared to lasers, mainly due to pricing. The only way to compare print quality is to see the same photo reproduced on each MFD on the manufacturer's recommended paper stock. Inkjet printers are cheaper up front, but are more expensive to run than laser printers—the inkjet cartridges don't last as long and are also costly.

In the mid- to long-term, you will need to replace ink cartridges several times, so find out how much these will cost and how many pages they are expected to print. Most manufacturers quote cartridge life based on the number of prints with ink covering five per cent of each page.

Saving space is one of the main criteria in the minds of people buying MFDs. The higher-end versions tend to get very tall, but don't take up any more desk space than a smaller unit. Smaller models have to make compromises somewhere—so decide how important space considerations are to you. However, MFDs today sacrifice little by way of quality and performance the way their forebears did.